



Imaging Binish Shreedharan

hindi hain hum!

Thanks to the efforts of a dedicated few, and the rise of open source software, applications such as KDE, GAIM and GNOME are now available in Hindi

Preethi Chamikutty

For long, computers in India have been restricted to those who understand English, cutting off a large potential user base. A movement has been taking shape since 1997 that could finally brought the power of computing to the masses.

The *Bharatbhasha* initiative was launched with the aim of providing free software to the masses. With the advent and growth of open source programs, this has become reality.

A volunteer project, IndLinux, focusing on widening the reach of computing to an estimated 1.3 billion people who understand Hindi, the fourth largest language group in the world, has been at the forefront of this movement. Founded by Prakash Advani and Venkatesh "Venky" Hariharan, IndLinux initially received support from FreeOS.com and is currently aided by Netcore Solutions.

Prakash Advani, who is also the Linux Practice Head, Onward Novell Software (I) Pvt Ltd, says, "For any technology to be adopted, it

has to be localised. For Linux to be accepted among the masses, it is necessary that we localise the common applications and interfaces. Translations are key foundations of the localisation effort, and so we decided to translate common applications such as KDE, GAIM and GNOME," says Advani.

How It All Started

IndLinux started working primarily on Hindi and helped set up localisation teams for other regional languages. The main goal of IndLinux is to create a fully Indian language-enabled distribution system.

The project started around the year 2000 with Advani and Hariharan joining forces. In the first two years of operations, the main bottleneck was fonts.

Says Guntapalli Karunakar, coordinator at IndLinux, "Our major problem was that we did not have good quality fonts, so the display wasn't very good. We have developed our own fonts—our design team and other artists helped design fonts, while the technical aspect was handled by myself and a few others." When the